land to his nephew. At this, Akbar sent the ataka khail to march against him with Kamal Khan, and they won.

Kamal Khan kept his uncle in jail ‘to the end of his days’,[15] and became sole ruler of the Gakkhars. And Akbar? He may not have shown the most laudable ethics in his conduct vis-à-vis Sultan Adam, but he had not only managed to keep the ataka khail away from court – and retaliatory bloodshed[16] – but also reversed the flow of obligation between the Gakkhars and his family. As long as he lived, Kamal Khan would not waver in his loyalty to the man who made him king.

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Far, far south of Kamal Khan’s newly acquired kingdom, meanwhile, a Tajik clerk was plotting to depose a Chandel queen.

Khwaja Abdul Majid had been a clerk in Humayun’s employ, and continued as an adviser to Akbar, who titled him ‘Asaf Khan’, after the wise vizier who served King Solomon. It wasn’t for his counsel, however, but for his military skill that Asaf Khan would be remembered. In the early years of Akbar’s reign, the scribe rose ‘*az qalm-b-ilm*’, from the pen to the military standard;[17] and Akbar’s eighth year as padishah began, in fact, with welcome news of Asaf Khan’s victory over Raja Ram Chand of Panna.

Only a little while earlier, the raja had allowed an envoy of Akbar’s to take away a most valued musician called Tansen, of whom Akbar had heard great things. Abul Fazl writes of how the raja considered the envoy’s arrival ‘an honour’, but it is more likely that Ram Chand resented the loss of Tansen’s legendary talent – not to mention all the ‘elephants of fame and valuable jewels’ he sent as tribute besides. He had a chance to express his unhappiness soon enough. An Afghan called Ghazi Khan[18] raised his banners against Akbar, and the raja gave him alliance and refuge.

Asaf Khan, who held a fief in central India, sniffed an opportunity in the raja’s insubordination. He sent Ram Chand a message, telling him to surrender Ghazi Khan and proclaim his allegiance to the Mughal throne. When the raja refused, Asaf Khan attacked – Ghazi Khan was killed, and Ram Chand surrendered his fragile independence along with ‘[i]mmense spoil’.[19]

It may have been hope of a similarly rich haul that turned Asaf Khan’s